Once I demonstrated what was possible, my words carried additional authority. Batting against spin has certain certainties. It's picking length, watching the revolutions on the ball. It's reading the drift, responding to variations, especially the one that goes straight on. You either want to get as close as possible to the pitch of the ball and smother, or as far away as possible, on the back foot, to allow the ball to spin before you select your shot. My message at the end of the game was disarmingly simple: we had to learn to trust our defence, and when to attack on our own terms.

India were a very good side, with stellar players, but they weren't in their pomp. I saw the first signs of self-doubt – we call it 'getting nippy' – and they gave away their underlying thinking by producing another turning wicket for the second Test in Mumbai. Usually they deliver a series of flat pitches after going one up in a series; here they were desperate to avenge their 4–0 whitewash in England.

Even the net wickets ragged. We selected Monty Panesar because we needed to play our two best spinners. He promptly took eleven wickets in a match that crystallized KP's capacity to destroy the opposition. His 186, against a ball that spat and spun, was one of the greatest innings by an England player.

There was an element of playing the percentages, since the ball was turning so much. That involves rationalized aggression, designed to knock the bowler off his length and rhythm. Because I am a left-hander, left-arm spinners aim at the rough outside my off stump. It can spin, bounce, or keep low. You can't retreat into yourself because you will be a sitting duck.

KP defended calmly and resolutely before attacking viciously and joyfully. He played with discipline, concentrating on the sweep and the slog sweep. We put on 206 for the third wicket. I ground out 122, by sweeping, nudging and nurdling, but my innings was colour-by-numbers stuff compared with his Impressionist masterpiece.

Sometimes captaincy is simple. Monty and Swanny were doing their bit by bowling brilliantly, and Jimmy Anderson was providing reverse swing, I didn't have to be a tactical genius. In Kolkata I lost the toss for a third time, and got my head down for eight hours, scoring 190 before enduring one of the biggest brain fades of my career.

I had shared big partnerships with Nick Compton and Jonathan Trott. I was well set, and ready to play the foil to KP. I was backing up to him and turned back to the crease after realizing a run wasn't on. Virat Kohli moved